

Pre-Listing Construction Checklist

What sellers should fix, what to disclose, and what to leave alone — from a licensed NC General Contractor. Use this before your listing goes live so prep work doesn't drag the price down or surprise the buyer.

Certified by

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How to use this checklist

Walk the property with this list in hand. For each item, decide: **fix it**, **disclose it**, or **leave it alone**. The fix-vs-disclose-vs-leave decision is rarely about what's broken — it's about **return on prep spend**. A \$200 fix that prevents a \$4,000 buyer-credit ask is worth doing; a \$4,000 fix that nets the seller an extra \$1,500 in price is not.

Section 1 — Exterior

Item	Fix	Skip	Why
Roof age 15+ years	✗	✓	Disclose and offer credit, don't replace before listing — buyer will negotiate either way
Visible roof damage (missing shingles, soft spots)	✓	✗	Patch repair — visible damage scares buyers far beyond cost to fix
Gutter detachment or rot	✓	✗	\$300–800 fix that signals neglect if left
Peeling exterior paint	✓	✗	FHA/VA appraisal flag — required to close those loans
Cracked driveway / walkway	✗	✓	Cosmetic in most cases — disclose and let buyer decide
Dead landscaping	✓	✗	\$200–600 mulch + fresh plantings = highest ROI prep spend
Worn front door / hardware	✓	✗	\$150–400 fix — biggest psychological signal at showing
Fence damage	✗	✓	Disclose unless safety hazard

Section 2 — Major Systems

Item	Fix	Skip	Why
HVAC 12+ years	✗	✓	Disclose age + service records, offer credit — replacement rarely returns cost

HVAC actively failing	✓	✗	Buyer will demand replacement at inspection — fix at your cost first
Water heater 8+ years	✗	✓	Disclose age — \$1,200 replacement vs \$1,500 buyer credit ask is wash
Active plumbing leaks	✓	✗	Always fix — leaks compound into structural problems quickly
Electrical panel under 100A or knob-and-tube	✓	✗	Insurability flag — buyer financing will require it anyway
GFCI outlets missing in kitchen/bath	✓	✗	\$100–200 per outlet, code requirement
Older single-pane windows	✗	✓	Disclose as \$X/window replacement opportunity

Section 3 — Interior

Item	Fix	Skip	Why
Carpet stains / wear	✓	✗	Replace or professionally clean — \$1,500–3,500 returns 2–3x at sale
Wall holes / scuffs	✓	✗	\$200–500 fix — buyers count every flaw at showing
Outdated bathroom (functional)	✗	✓	\$8,000+ remodel rarely returns full cost — disclose with credit option
Outdated kitchen (functional)	✗	✓	\$15,000+ remodel almost never breaks even on a sale
Sticky doors / window operation	✓	✗	\$50–150 fix that signals overall property care
Cracked tile / grout	✓	✗	\$300–800 fix — visible damage spirals in buyer's mind
Cosmetic ceiling stains	✓	✗	Stain-block + paint = \$100, signals roof leaks if left
Dated paint colors	✓	✗	Single best ROI item — \$1,500–3,000 returns 5–10x

Section 4 — Disclosure-critical items

These items **must be disclosed** in NC residential property transactions. Failing to disclose creates legal exposure. Pre-decide how each gets framed in the Residential Property Disclosure (RPDS).

Al w a y s di s cl o s e	
■	Any past water intrusion (basement, crawlspace, attic, roof)
■	Known foundation movement, settlement, or repair history
■	Past pest treatment (termite, carpenter ant, rodent)
■	Any insurance claim filed on the property
■	Underground oil tanks (active or decommissioned)
■	Permitted vs unpermitted work history
■	Septic system age + last pump date
■	Well water quality test history

Section 5 — Prep-spend budget guide

Use this rule-of-thumb framework when deciding how much to spend on pre-listing prep:

Price range	Typical prep spend	Focus areas
Under \$300K	\$1,500–4,000	Paint, landscaping, cleaning, front door, minor repairs
\$300K–500K	\$3,000–8,000	Above + carpet, light fixtures, hardware, deep clean
\$500K–750K	\$6,000–15,000	Above + selective updates (bathroom paint, kitchen hardware), staging
\$750K+	\$12,000–30,000+	Above + premium finish details, professional staging

Section 6 — Hire a contractor or DIY?

Hi re a li c e n s e d c o n t r a c t o r w h e n	
■	Permit is required (electrical panel, plumbing relocation, structural)
■	Work touches building envelope (roof, siding, windows)
■	Insurance/warranty preservation matters (HVAC, water heater)
■	Buyer financing will require licensed work (FHA, VA, USDA)
■	Cost over \$3,000 — the labor savings rarely justify DIY risk

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| ■ | Interior paint (with proper prep) |
| ■ | Light landscaping and mulch |
| ■ | Hardware and fixture replacement |
| ■ | Caulking, weatherstripping, minor wall repair |
| ■ | Deep cleaning and detail work |

When you want a GC-backed read on YOUR listing

Southern Cities offers a Pre-Listing Construction Valuation — a licensed GC reads your specific property and tells you exactly what to fix, what to disclose, and how the condition affects your asking price. \$399, 1-business-day turnaround.

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